

1857-1900

IMPERIALISM

In the late 19th century, the world was reshaped as Western nations embarked on an unprecedented scramble for overseas territories. Competition between nations played a part in this drive for control: Britain hoped to recover its stature after losing its American colonies; France wanted to rebuild its power after the Napoleonic wars; Russia continued to push east into the weakening Qing Empire in China; and from the 1860s, the young nations of Germany, Italy, and the United States sought to become world powers. Rapidly modernizing after centuries of isolation, Japan was also keen to gain access to resources and territory it lacked. A misguided moral mission was also used to justify the

conquest of, and increasing control over, lands across Asia, Africa, the Caribbean, and Australasia.

Industrialization was a key force behind imperialism because it demanded access to raw materials, labour, and new markets. Industrialization also made imperialism possible. Modern weapons and rapid transport meant that local resistance could be quashed in what sometimes became genocide, while telegraphic communication meant that large areas could be easily controlled. Modern medicine, particularly the discovery of quinine as a treatment for malaria, aided the spread of imperialism because the colonizers were less susceptible to the disease.



KEY MOMENTS

1857-58 The British take control of India

After suppressing a major revolt in 1857-58 (left), the British government placed British India and its princely states under direct rule by the Crown – the Raj. In 1876, Queen Victoria became Empress of India.

1876 Scramble for Africa

In 1876, King Leopold II of Belgium began colonizing the Congo, prompting Europe's powers to gather at the Berlin Conference (1884-85) to decide how they could carve up Africa between them. By 1900, Europeans ruled over 90 per cent of Africa (left) and its valuable natural resources.

1870s Social goals

Underpinning Western imperialism was a pseudo-scientific belief in the superiority of the white man and a perceived moral duty to rule, civilize, educate (left), and Christianize “native” peoples. The resulting policies typically wrought havoc on Indigenous cultures around the world.

